

Qroo Spanish Crew

Conjugating Verbs in the Imperfect Subjunctive

Introduction

This guide focuses exclusively on how to conjugate into the imperfect subjunctive, not when. The easiest way to learn when is to learn constructions that “trigger” the subjunctive. You can learn triggers by watching my videos on the subject.

The imperfect subjunctive has two interchangeable forms: one using **-ra** endings and the other using **-se** endings. The **-ra** form is more commonly used in spoken Spanish, so we will focus on it here.

Formation of the Imperfect Subjunctive

To conjugate a verb in the imperfect subjunctive:

1. Start with the **ellos/ellas/ustedes** form of the verb in the preterit tense.
2. Remove the **-ron** ending to find the stem.
3. Add the appropriate imperfect subjunctive ending.

Imperfect Subjunctive Endings (-ra Form)

Subject Pronoun	Ending
yo	-ra
tú	-ras
él/ella/usted	-ra
nosotros/nosotras	-ramos
vosotros/vosotras (Spain only)	-rais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	-ran

Note: In the **nosotros** form, add a written accent on the vowel before **ramos**.

Regular Verbs

Examples of Regular Verbs

-AR Verbs

- **Hablar (to speak):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	hablara
tú	hablaras
él/ella/usted	hablara
nosotros	habláramos
vosotros	hablarais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	hablaran

-ER Verbs

- **Comer (to eat):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	comiera
tú	comieras
él/ella/usted	comiera
nosotros	comiéramos
vosotros	comierais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	comieran

-IR Verbs

- **Vivir (to live):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
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yo	viviera
tú	vivieras
él/ella/usted	viviera
nosotros	viviéramos
vosotros	vivierais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	vivieran

Irregular Verbs

Irregular verbs in the imperfect subjunctive maintain the irregular stem from the **ellos/ellas/ustedes** form of the preterit tense.

Examples of Common Irregular Verbs

Hacer (to do/make):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	hiciera
tú	hicieras
él/ella/usted	hiciera
nosotros	hiciéramos
vosotros	hicierais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	hicieran

Ser / Ir (to be / to go):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	fuera
tú	fueras

él/ella/usted	fuera
nosotros	fuéramos
vosotros	fuerais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	fueran

Tener (to have):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	tuviera
tú	tuvieras
él/ella/usted	tuviera
nosotros	tuviéramos
vosotros	tuvierais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	tuvieran

Decir (to say):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	dijera
tú	dijeras
él/ella/usted	dijera
nosotros	dijéramos
vosotros	dijerais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	dijeran

Poder (to be able to):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
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yo	pudiera
tú	pudieras
él/ella/usted	pudiera
nosotros	pudiéramos
vosotros	pudierais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	pudieran

Summary

The imperfect subjunctive provides two conjugation forms, with the **-ra** form being more common. It is formed using the **ellos/ellas/ustedes** stem from the preterit tense and adding the appropriate endings. Remembering irregular stems from the preterit will help with irregular verbs like **hacer**, **tener**, and **ser/ir**.